

## The harsh reality of child labour in rural Bihar

Despite Government efforts, the economic realities force families to make children work, **often resulting in their exploitation**

**Baiju** (name changed), an 11-year-old boy from Telia village in Kudhni block, 22 km from Muzaffarpur in Bihar, **wakes up** every morning like other children. However, instead of going to school, he **heads off** to work as a labourer, a **burden** he has **borne** for the past three years. Baiju, who belongs to the Mahadalit community, used to attend school. Life changed after his father's death, as he was forced to **drop out** of school and start working to support his family. He explains that his mother's **meagre** income is not enough to **sustain** the six members of their family.

**Consequently**, he had to **give up** his education and begin working. She does not have enough money to educate her children, forcing her to send Baiju to work.

Child labour is a **grave** issue affecting millions of children worldwide, and in our country, it has reached **alarming** proportions. According to a UNICEF report based on the 2011 census, there are approximately 10.1 million child labourers in India, including 5.6 million boys and 4.5 million girls. Most child labourers can be found working in domestic services, tea shops, and brick kilns. In India, child labour is more **prevalent** in rural areas compared to urban ones. **Children** from socially and economically **disadvantaged** communities **are** often **compelled** to work in these areas, **stripping** them **of** their fundamental right to education and **perpetuating** the cycle of **poverty**.

This not only obstructs their education but also **hampers** their overall development. Children should be in school and playing, not **toiling** as labourers. **Pinki Devi** (name changed), a 45-year-old resident of Telia village, **has** two children who have left school to work as labourers. She explains that her **husband**, a daily wage labourer, **is** often **ill**. In such a situation, it became impossible to support the family with his income alone, forcing her to send her children to work.

Social worker Phuldev Patel **points out** that **children** from the most economically **vulnerable** Dalit and Mahadalit communities **are** **predominantly** involved in child labour. The **dire** economic **conditions** of their households **compel** them to **abandon** their education and start working. He **asserts** that the actual number of child labourers is significantly higher than what official **statistics** reveal.

The government provides free books, notebooks, uniforms, and mid-day meals under the Right to Free and Compulsory Education to **encourage** children to attend school. However, the harsh economic realities **overshadow** these **provisions**, pushing children into labour. He further notes that human **traffickers** **exploit** this **vulnerability**, selling children as labourers in other states. Local journalist Amritanj observes that, like Telia village, there are **numerous** **remote** rural areas in Muzaffarpur where children work as labourers. He notes that the government may not have official

statistics on this issue because it is **carried out** in a highly **systematic** manner. Although the strict child labour laws and the **vigilance** of the local administration have reduced the rate of child labourers in recent years, it has not been entirely **eradicated**. Even today, children can be seen working in **brick kilns**, tea shops, grocery stores, construction sites, and as domestic helpers. As in previous years, this year too, the World Day Against Child Labor was **observed** on June 12 in India and around the world. When **children** in a society **begin** working as labourers at a young age instead of attending school, it prompts deep **introspection** within that nation and its society. They must **confront** why a child is forced to abandon books for labour. When a child's right to childhood, is denied, and they are **thrust** into labour, they **endure** physical, mental, and social exploitation, transforming their childhood into one **marred** by labour—an **ordeal** known as child labour.

[\[Practice Exercise\]](#)

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'

## Vocabulary

1. **Harsh** (adjective) – Severe, tough, stringent, unkind, cruel कठोर
2. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly, usually अक्सर
3. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, cause, bring about, give rise to, produce के परिणामस्वरूप होना
4. **Exploitation** (noun) – Abuse, misuse, manipulation, taking advantage of, unfair treatment शोषण
5. **Wake up** (phrasal verb) – Arise, get up, awaken, come to consciousness, rise जागना
6. **Head off** (to) (phrasal verb) – Go to, move towards, proceed to, set out for, make one's way to के लिए रवाना होना
7. **Bear the burden of** (phrase) – Endure, carry, shoulder, cope with, handle का बोझ उठाना
8. **Drop out** (phrasal verb) – Leave, quit, withdraw, give up, abandon छोड़ना
9. **Meagre** (adjective) – Insufficient, scanty, paltry, inadequate, sparse अल्प
10. **Sustain** (verb) – Support, maintain, keep up, uphold, nourish पोषण करना
11. **Consequently** (adverb) – As a result, therefore, hence, thus, subsequently परिणामस्वरूप
12. **Give up** (phrasal verb) – Abandon, relinquish, quit, surrender, cease त्याग देना
13. **Grave** (adjective) – Serious, severe, critical, significant, weighty गंभीर
14. **Alarming** (adjective) – Disturbing, frightening, worrying, shocking, startling चिंताजनक
15. **Prevalent** (adjective) – Widespread, common, pervasive, rampant, ubiquitous प्रचलित
16. **Disadvantaged** (adjective) – Underprivileged, deprived, poor, needy, impoverished वंचित
17. **Compel** (verb) – Force, oblige, necessitate, pressure, coerce मजबूर करना
18. **Strip of** (phrasal verb) – Deprive of, take away, remove, dispossess, divest छीन लेना
19. **Perpetuate** (verb) – Continue, maintain, sustain, prolong, preserve बनाए रखना
20. **Poverty** (noun) – Deprivation, destitution, indigence, impoverishment, need गरीबी
21. **Hamper** (verb) – Hinder, obstruct, impede, inhibit, restrict बाधा डालना

22. **Toil** (verb) – Labor, work hard, drudge, struggle, exert oneself मेहनत करना
23. **Ill** (adjective) – Sick, unwell, unhealthy, ailing, infirm बीमार
24. **Point out** (phrasal verb) – Indicate, mention, note, highlight, draw attention to इंगित करना
25. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – Susceptible, exposed, at risk, defenseless, weak असुरक्षित
26. **Predominately** (adverb) – Mainly, primarily, chiefly, largely, mostly मुख्य रूप से
27. **Dire** (adjective) – Terrible, dreadful, extreme, severe, urgent भयानक
28. **Abandon** (verb) – Leave, forsake, desert, give up, relinquish त्यागना
29. **Assert** (verb) – Declare, state, affirm, claim, insist दावा करना
30. **Statistic** (noun) – Data point, figure, number, metric, piece of data आँकड़ा
31. **Encourage** (verb) – Support, promote, inspire, stimulate, motivate प्रोत्साहित करना
32. **Overshadow** (verb) – appear more prominent or important than. पर भारी पड़ना
33. **Provision** (noun) – Supply, provision, furnishing, allocation, distribution प्रावधान
34. **Trafficker** (noun) – Smuggler, dealer, trader, peddler, illicit trader तस्कर
35. **Exploit** (verb) – Take advantage of, misuse, abuse, manipulate, utilize शोषण करना
36. **Vulnerability** (noun) – Susceptibility, weakness, exposure, risk, defenselessness असुरक्षा
37. **Numerous** (adjective) – Many, several, countless, myriad, abundant कई
38. **Remote** (adjective) – Distant, faraway, isolated, outlying, secluded दूरस्थ
39. **Carry out** (phrasal verb) – Perform, conduct, execute, implement, accomplish करना
40. **Systematic** (adjective) – Methodical, organized, structured, planned, orderly व्यवस्थित
41. **Vigilance** (noun) – Watchfulness, alertness, attentiveness, caution, surveillance चौकसी
42. **Eradicate** (verb) – Eliminate, remove, abolish, destroy, wipe out समाप्त करना
43. **Brick kiln** (noun) – A furnace or oven for burning bricks, often a place where bricks are made and fired ईंट भट्ठा
44. **Observe** (verb) – Celebrate, keep, remember, perform मनाना

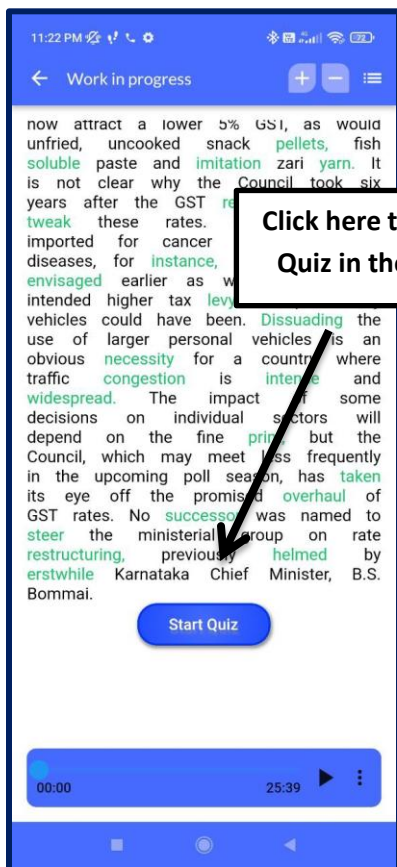
45. **Introspection** (noun) – Self-examination, reflection, contemplation, self-analysis, meditation आत्मनिरीक्षण
46. **Confront** (verb) – Face, tackle, challenge, address, oppose सामना करना
47. **Thrust** (into) (verb) – Push, force, insert, drive, propel डालना
48. **Endure** (verb) – Suffer, bear, withstand, tolerate, sustain सहना
49. **Mar** (verb) – Spoil, damage, impair, tarnish, blemish बिगाड़ना
50. **Ordeal** (noun) – Trial, hardship, suffering, tribulation, difficulty कठिनाई

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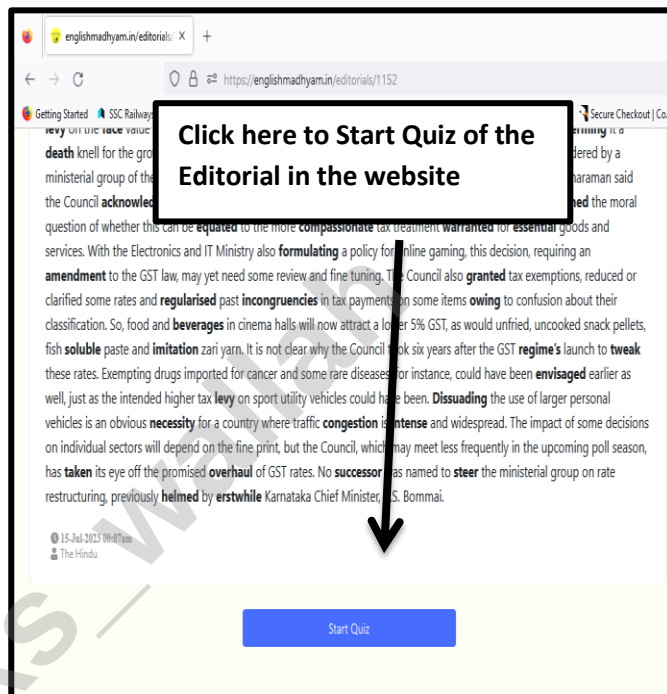
### Summary of the Editorial

1. **Baiju's Story:** Baiju, an 11-year-old from Telia village in Bihar, had to leave school and start working after his father's death to support his family.
2. **Economic Pressures:** Baiju's mother cannot afford to educate her children, forcing Baiju to work to help sustain the family of six.
3. **Prevalence of Child Labour:** Child labour is a significant issue in India, affecting 10.1 million children, as per UNICEF's 2011 census data.
4. **Rural Impact:** Child labour is more prevalent in rural areas, especially among socially and economically disadvantaged communities.
5. **Educational Impact:** Working children are deprived of their right to education and overall development, perpetuating poverty.
6. **Pinki Devi's Plight:** Pinki Devi, another resident of Telia, had to send her children to work due to her husband's illness and insufficient income.
7. **Vulnerable Communities:** Social worker Phuldev Patel highlights that children from Dalit and Mahadalit communities are most affected by child labour.
8. **Underreported Statistics:** The actual number of child labourers is higher than official statistics suggest.
9. **Government Initiatives:** The government provides free educational resources and mid-day meals to encourage school attendance.
10. **Economic Reality:** Despite these provisions, severe economic conditions drive children into labour.
11. **Exploitation by Traffickers:** Human traffickers exploit the vulnerability of these children, selling them as labourers in other states.
12. **Systematic Child Labour:** Journalist Amritanj notes that in many rural areas, child labour is systematically carried out, evading official statistics.
13. **Legal and Administrative Efforts:** Strict child labour laws and vigilant local administration have reduced but not eradicated child labour.
14. **Visible Labour:** Children are still seen working in various sectors like brick kilns, tea shops, grocery stores, construction sites, and as domestic helpers.
15. **Call for Introspection:** The ongoing issue of child labour demands deep societal introspection about why children are forced into labour instead of attending school, highlighting their exploitation and denied childhood.

## Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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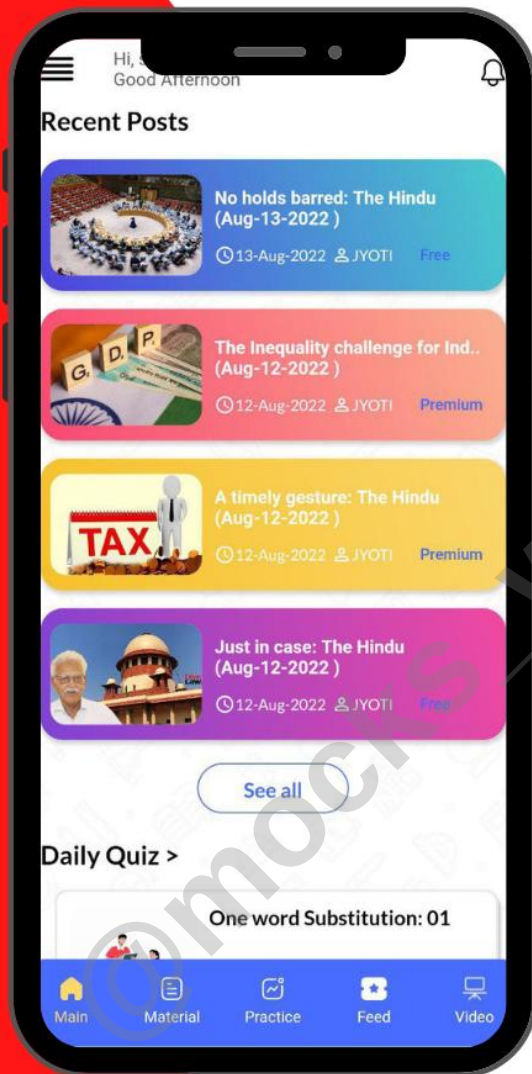


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